

and had never even balanced a checkbook. In fact, she didn't even know where the checkbook was. Bob gave her money weekly, not unlike the allowance he doled out to the children.

Anne told me she felt more like one of the children than an equal partner in the marriage. This intelligent and competent woman came to believe that her abilities were no greater than those of her young children. She had not been allowed to make adult decisions without consulting her husband first, and in some cases, like the family finances, she knew to not even mention it. Whenever she did, Bob's favorite response was, "Don't worry. I'll take care of you." Anne interpreted this response as, "You can't take care of yourself."

This fear of living independently without her husband to rely on had so paralyzed Anne that she couldn't even entertain the thought. She didn't have the conviction that she was capable on her own so she was powerless to break out of a controlling marriage. She had become a "financial infant," with her husband the financial parent. The following statements are those of a financial infant:

1. My money situation is upsetting, but I feel I won't ever get into any real trouble because there's always someone to rescue me. I can count on my spouse, parents, brother, sister, or friends.
2. I want to be taken care of. It was nice when I was a child because everything was provided. I want it to remain that way.
3. I have a desire to remain dependent. I don't want to become self-reliant.

To many young adults, dependence on their parents is comforting. By not moving out, the financial decisions and worries can be delayed. If there are no financial obligations

